

Ὅρφικὰ ποιήματα

Hymns, Cosmogony, and the Orphic Poems

eul_aid: lea

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)

Dialect: Ἑπική [Epic \(Homeric\)](#)

Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)

Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)

The Orphic Poems are a collection of ancient Greek religious texts attributed to the mythical singer Orpheus. Orpheus was a legendary Thracian bard, famous for his magical music and his journey to the underworld to retrieve his wife, Eurydice. He was not a historical author but a figurehead for a religious movement known as Orphism, which began in the 6th century BCE. Followers, called Orpheotelests, used his name to authorize their teachings.

The surviving works are not complete poems but fragments of a vast, evolving corpus. They include theogonies, hymns, and ritual instructions. Well-known collections attributed to this tradition are the Sacred Discourses in Twenty-Four Rhapsodies and the Orphic Hymns, the latter being a set of 87 hymns likely composed in the 2nd or 3rd century CE.

According to modern scholars, these poems were central to Orphic belief. They presented a unique creation story, different from Hesiod's, which often began with the god Chronos. A key myth involved the dismemberment of the child-god Dionysus, which was used to explain the Orphic idea that the human body is a prison for a divine soul. The texts provided the foundation for rituals of purification and initiation aimed at securing a blessed afterlife. Orphic ideas significantly influenced later Greek philosophers, including Plato, and the hymns remain a primary source for understanding late antique religious practice.

Works (10)

- Ἀργοναυτικά · [Argonautica](#) · 72 passages
- Ἀστρολογικὸν Ἀπόσπασμα · [Astrological Fragment](#) · 8 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Βοτανῶν Ἱατρικῶν · [Fragments on Medicinal Herbs](#) · 5 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα Π. Δερβενίου · [Fragments P. Derveni](#) · 24 passages
- Ὕμνοι · [Hymns](#) · 190 passages
- Περὶ λίθων · [On Stones](#) · 60 passages
- Περὶ λίθων · [On Stones](#) · 43 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα · [Orphic Cosmogony and Soul Fragments](#) · 25 passages
- Προκηρύξεις περὶ λίθων · [Proclamations-Stones](#) · 53 passages
- Μαρτυρίαι · [Testimonies](#) · 25 passages